Losing Cuba

In the 1960 Presidential election Kennedy used Cuba against his Republican opponent. Just as the Democrats had 'lost China' under Truman, Kennedy chided Eisenhower for losing Cuba and allowing 'a Communist satellite ninety miles off the coast of the United States.'[33] At his election rallies, Kennedy declared: 'Those who say they will stand up to Mr Khrushchev have demonstrated no ability to stand up to Mr. Castro.'[34] Within the Eisenhower administration, Vice President Nixon had pressed the CIA to speed up the overthrow of Castro, and he believed that Kennedy had been improperly briefed on the agency's preparations. So, when Kennedy campaign staff suggested their candidate favoured intervention in Cuba, Nixon was furious, but was publicly obliged to disavow such action.

Kennedy's lack of government experience, and that of his senior officials, meant the new administration was ill-equipped to challenge recommendations from CIA officials whose experience of covert action had successfully promoted US interests and undermined Washington's adversaries. The President had yet to develop a feel for the judgement of his advisers (most of whom served him poorly at this time). Although instinctively drawn to the world of covert action, special forces, and counterinsurgency, he had limited understanding of how to manage complex secret operations. What he did have was a clear view that covert action needed to be covert. Any US involvement needed to be hidden.

Hypocrisy and cynicism?

The CIA plan for an amphibious landing was endorsed by Eisenhower. In November 1960 Ike met the president-elect with Allen Dulles and Richard Bissell, the Deputy Director of the CIA. Bissell was the principal architect of (and advocate for) the plan. He was well-known and respected by Kennedy and his senior officials, and it was widely believed that JFK saw him as a successor to Dulles.

On 19 January 1961, the day before his inauguration, Kennedy was told by Eisenhower that it was his responsibility 'to do whatever is necessary' in